



T-storm, shower 68/64 • Tomorrow: T-storm, shower 74/66 B6

Democracy Dies in Darkness

TUESDAY, MAY 13, 2025 • \$4

Combs trial opens with sordid testimony

Sex worker describes violence, threat in rap mogul's trafficking trial

BY ANNE BRANIGIN,
JANAY KINGSBERRY,
SHAYNA JACOBS
AND SABBY ROBINSON

NEW YORK — Sean “Diddy” Combs’s federal sex trafficking trial began Monday with opening statements and searing testimony from witnesses who detailed alleged violence, paid sex acts and coercion by the music mogul.

Combs, who has pleaded not guilty to five criminal counts of racketeering conspiracy, sex trafficking and transportation to engage in prostitution, entered the courtroom at the Daniel Patrick Moynihan U.S. Courthouse, embraced his attorneys and greeted his family seated in the row behind him with a smile. He faces 15 years to life in prison if convicted on all counts.

After jurors were selected and sworn in by Judge Arun Subramanian, proceedings continued with witness testimony from former hotel security guard Israel Florez and sex worker Daniel Phillip, who detailed their interactions with Combs. The jury was also shown surveillance footage of Combs dragging and beating his then-girlfriend Cassie — whose legal name is Casandra Ventura — at a hotel in 2016.

During opening statements, prosecutors described Combs’s alleged “freak offs” — drug- and sex-fueled parties — and the “high-ranking” employees tied to his alleged crimes. They also outlined how victims, including Ventura and another former romantic partner identified only as “Jane,” were forced or coerced into sex acts at these events.

“They will describe freak offs for you in painstaking detail,” Assistant U.S. Attorney Emily Johnson told the jury — along with “some of the most painful and personal experiences of their

SEE COMBS ON A8

States vie to snag a piece of \$100 billion AI megaproject

BY CAROLINE O'DONOVAN

Linda Tiso could sell the 63-acre farm she grew up on in Kenosha, Wisconsin, to a residential developer but wants her inheritance to be part of “an investment in the future.”

So when ChatGPT maker OpenAI launched a nationwide search for sites for Stargate, a \$100 billion project building data centers for artificial intelligence, she and her husband offered to make a deal.

“We have some property for sale in Wisconsin,” Tiso’s husband wrote to an OpenAI staffer on LinkedIn. He highlighted the land’s proximity to power lines and included a cellphone number.

“It’s a good thing to be bringing here,” Tiso told The Washington Post.

The Tisos — who are still waiting for a call — are players in a pageant of real estate developers, landowners, economic development agencies and elected officials vying for a piece of Stargate, which is being promoted as a

SEE STARGATE ON A16



HEIDI LEVINE/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Joy in Tel Aviv as people watch the release of Israeli American hostage Edan Alexander, who was freed after U.S.- Hamas negotiations.

In Israel, U.S. snubs provoke ‘panic’

As Trump repeatedly sidelines Netanyahu, anxious leaders perceive cracks in relationship

BY GERRY SHIH

JERUSALEM — During his first major overseas trip this week, President Donald Trump is set to visit three countries in the Middle East — Saudi Arabia, Qatar and the United Arab Emirates — without stopping in Jerusalem.

It’s not the first time he has bypassed Israel — or Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu.

From embarking on nuclear talks with Iran to attempting hos-

tage talks with Hamas without Israel’s knowledge, Trump has increasingly sidelined Netanyahu, stoking anxieties in a country long accustomed to being consulted by successive U.S. administrations.

Last week, Israelis thought they saw more cracks emerge between the “America First” president and Israel, after Trump said he had struck a truce with Yemen’s Houthi rebels that curbed the group’s attacks on U.S. ships — but

did not cover Israel. Days later, reports emerged that Trump was considering offering Saudi Arabia access to civil nuclear technology without demanding that the kingdom normalize relations with Israel, a precondition that had been set by President Joe Biden.

On Sunday, senior Hamas leader Khalil al-Hayya said the group would release Israeli American hostage Edan Alexander following direct talks with U.S. officials.

Now, many Israelis are wonder-

ing whether Israel is the next U.S. ally to be left behind by a president they considered, just months ago, to be the most pro-Israel in history.

“It’s disconcerting,” said Michael Oren, a former Israeli ambassador to Washington.

“It’s total panic,” said Shalom Lipner, a former Netanyahu aide

SEE ISRAEL ON A11

Hostage freed: Hamas keys move to ceasefire talks with Israel. **A12**

Gifted Qatar plane would need extensive security upgrades

This story is by Natalie Allison, Ellen Nakashima, Dan Lamothe, Derek Hawkins and Warren P. Strobel

President Donald Trump on Monday praised Qatar for offering his administration a free luxury jet, but current and former U.S. military, defense and Secret Service officials said he will likely have to waive existing

security specifications to be able to use the plane.

Trump said he would be a “stupid person” not to accept the gift of a \$400 million Boeing 747-8, and called it a “great gesture” by Qatar. The president said that he intended to use the plane for a “couple of years” while his administration waits for a pair of Boeing planes to be completed to the strict military

standards befitting Air Force One.

A White House official said it was premature to say how long upgrades to the Qatari plane could take. The official, who was not authorized to discuss the matter publicly and spoke on the condition of anonymity, like others interviewed, also declined to say when the Trump administration expects to take possession.

Flight records show that the Qatari jet was moved five weeks ago to San Antonio International Airport, suggesting that preparations for improvements might already be underway.

The Wall Street Journal first reported this month that Trump

SEE QATAR ON A13

The Fix: A gift that could awaken Trump’s “corrupt” problem. **A2**



SAUL LOEB/AFP/GETTY IMAGES

Afrikaner arrivals

The first White South Africans to arrive for resettlement as refugees in the United States listen to Deputy Secretary of State Christopher Landau on Monday at Dulles Airport. The Trump administration gave them refugee status but has denied it to all other foreign groups. **Story, A11**

Order on drug costs offers plenty of threats, few details

Trump’s directive unlikely to provide any relief in near term

BY DANIEL GILBERT

President Donald Trump signed an executive order Monday that aims to coax pharmaceutical companies into offering lower prices in the United States, taking a historically broad swipe at the cost of medicine but without clear mechanisms for providing fast relief to American patients.

The order, with little detail, targets drug pricing on a potentially broader scale than Trump did in his first administration, but his directive lacks teeth that would compel lower prices in the near term. In a telling signal, the stock prices of numerous large pharmaceutical companies rose Monday, along with the rest of the market as it reacted to news of lower China tariffs.

Experts said the plan lacks enough detail to determine

whether patients would realize any tangible benefits and pointed out it is likely to face court challenges. The order did not state whether the administration would be seeking lower prices in Medicare, Medicaid or private insurance markets — or all of the above.

In his remarks, Trump indicated he had an expansive vision: The “cost for Medicaid and Medicare, and just basically pharmaceuticals and drugs is going down at a level that nobody has ever seen before.”

Far from demonizing pharmaceutical companies for high prices, Trump focused his fire on countries, particularly in the European Union, for negotiating drug prices so low that they leave the United States to subsidize the global costs of innovation. He is directing his administration to investigate countries that “extort drug companies by blocking their products unless they accept bottom line and very low dollar

SEE DRUG PRICES ON A4

Medicaid: The GOP’s scaled-back plan risks coverage for millions. **A2**

IN THE NEWS

A season on the brink The Capitals lose 5-2 to the Hurricanes and are one loss away from elimination in the NHL playoffs. **D1**

Homelessness in D.C. After two years of increases, the unhoused population in the District fell 9 percent, according to the Point-In-Time census. **B1**

THE NATION Officers who sexually abuse children will go free as police accountability measures are scrapped, some fear. **A3**
Erie, Pennsylvania, is divided over DEI grants to small businesses. **A6**

THE WORLD The India-Pakistan ceasefire is holding, but the battle lines appear to have changed. **A10**
The PKK Kurdish militant group said it will end its armed struggle against Turkey. **A14**

THE ECONOMY Online scammers who are posing as lawyers are targeting immigrants and taking their money. **A15**
As a U.S. citizen living abroad, Pope Leo XIV might still be required to file an annual income tax return with the IRS. **A15**

THE REGION Student journalists in Alexandria are lobbying against a policy that allows their principal to review and edit stories before publication. **B1**
D.C.’s attorney general is suing the former director of a housing nonprofit, alleging a misallocation of funds. **B1**

SPORTS The Wizards’ hopes for the first overall pick were dashed. Dallas lucked into the right to pick Cooper Flagg; Washington will pick sixth. **D1**
HEALTH & SCIENCE The strange light of auroras has some fascinating astronomical science behind it. **E1**

BUSINESS NEWS.....A15
COMICS.....C5
OBITUARIES.....B4
OPINION PAGES.....A17
TELEVISION.....C4
WORLD NEWS.....A10

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post
Year 148, No. 54215

